



ASSEMBLY Elections 08

Voters in six states will queue up at polling booths in Delhi, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jammu and Kashmir and Mizoram in assembly elections staggered over the next eight weeks which are seen as a prelude to the Lok Sabha polls next year. In four of the states, the BJP and Congress are pitted against each other with the score reading 3-1 in BJP's favour now.

Although state elections focus on local governance, the performance of the Central Government will be a major factor. L.K. Advani, who is using the campaign as a dry run for his prime ministerial bid next year, will use both rising prices and internal security concerns to launch savage attacks on the Government.

To extrapolate assembly results and plan for the Lok Sabha elections is fraught with danger as the BJP found out to its dismay in 2004, when, bolstered by its win in three of the same four states, it called for early elections. But the Congress desperately needs an electoral win to boost its morale. The voters will decide soon. After that, it is up to the party high command to interpret the electoral leaves.

by Priya Sahgal

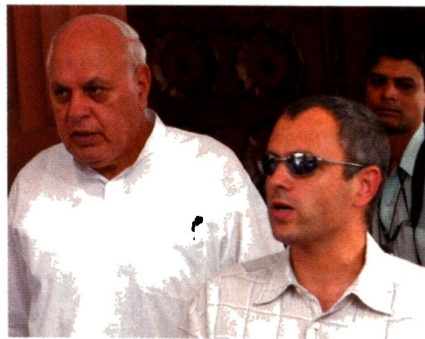


Regional Refuge

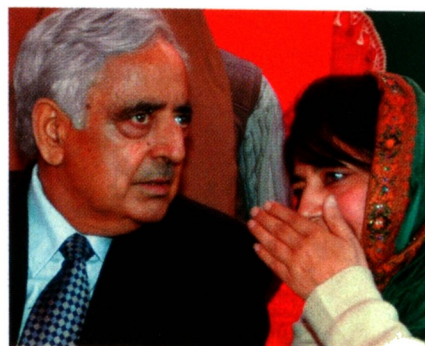
It was a ploy to appease the 40-lakh-strong votebank in Delhi. The Chhath puja, a thanksgiving festival popular in Bihar and far eastern Uttar Pradesh, became the haute destination as leaders of all hues raced to the banks of the river Yamuna to offer their prayers before the sun set. The usual noises were made with BJP's chief ministerial candidate V.K. Malhotra even announcing that he would declare Chhath an official holiday if he came to power. Not to be left behind was Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit who recalled how she had set up a Bhojpuri Akademi in Delhi. L.K. Advani too jumped on to this rather popular bandwagon and issued a press release stating that "society should co-operate with the people of Bihar". Well, they've all said their prayers. Election day will tell whose prayers were heard.

by Shyamial Yadav

V.K. MALHOTRA TAKES PART IN THE CHHATH FESTIVITIES IN THE CAPITAL



SIPRA DAS



YASIN DAR

With PDP deciding to contest the state polls, the stage has been set for an electoral battle between the two leading political families of the Valley—the Abdullahs and the Muftis. The nc is banking entirely on the charisma of Farooq Abdullah, who is its chief ministerial candidate. As the only cadre-based party with its support base in both Jammu and the Valley, the nc stands to benefit the most from the separatists' poll boycott campaign. In a calculated gambit to outdo nc's internal autonomy card, the Muftis have pitched the self-rule demand as their key poll plank. The deciding card may well be

FAROOQ AND OMAR ABDULLAH (TOP); MUFTI MOHAMMAD SAYEED WITH MEHBOOBA MUFTI

with the Congress which true to its style runs with the hare and hunts with the hounds.

by Ramesh Vinayak